

WORKSHOP · 45 MINUTES

From Story to Statement

How to Write Powerful College & Scholarship Essays in English

The U For You · Chitre 2026

LET'S START

Which essay got into college?

Essay A

"I am a passionate and dedicated student who has always excelled in academics. My GPA of 3.8 and my leadership in student council demonstrate my commitment to excellence..."

VS

Essay B

"The goat escaped at 5am. I chased it barefoot through the mud, cursing in two languages, and realized this was the third time this month I'd chosen the farm over sleep..."

Raise your hand. Which one?

They are not admitting your grades. They are admitting your story.

Most students write...

- Resume essays (listing achievements)
- "I am passionate about..." essays
- Safe essays (what parents want)
- Essays about achievements, not growth

Admissions officers want...

- Reflection
- Vulnerability
- Growth
- Self-awareness
- Specificity

The S.T.O.R.Y. Framework

Every powerful essay follows this structure.

S

Scene

Where were you? What did you see, hear, feel?

T

Tension

What challenge, conflict, or question appeared?

O

Ownership

What did YOU do? Not what happened to you.

R

Reflection

What changed in you? What did you understand?

Y

Why college now?

How does this connect to your future?

EXAMPLE

[S] At fourteen, I froze in front of 200 people at my first debate tournament.

[T] My hands shook. My mind went blank. I walked off stage.

[O] The next week, I signed up again. And the week after that.

[R] I learned that courage isn't the absence of fear. It's the decision to speak anyway.

[Y] That's why I want to study Communications — not to avoid silence, but to fill it with purpose.

Upgrade Your Writing

Instead of "I like"

- I am drawn to
- I became fascinated by
- I found myself deeply engaged in

Instead of "I learned"

- I discovered
- I realized
- I developed
- I overcame

Instead of "very happy"

- fulfilled
- empowered
- challenged
- transformed

Activity: Upgrade this sentence

"I like science and I learned a lot from it."

Transform it using power words. You have 2 minutes.

Pick ONE prompt. Find YOUR story.

Prompt 1

Describe a moment you felt different.

Prompt 2

Describe a failure that changed you.

Prompt 3

Describe a problem in your community you wish to solve.

Prompt 4

Describe something people misunderstand about you.

Pair work: Tell your partner your story in 2 minutes. Then switch.

Write your first paragraph. Now.

LEVEL 1 — EMERGING

I used to think _____.
Everything changed when _____.
That experience taught me _____.
Today, I want to study _____
because _____.

LEVEL 2 — INTERMEDIATE

The moment that challenged me the
most was _____.
At first, I felt _____.
However, I decided to _____.
Looking back, I now understand
_____.

LEVEL 3 — ADVANCED

Write your first 120 words using
S.T.O.R.Y.

Start with the scene. Put us there.
Make us feel it.

You have 8 minutes. Go.

Read your partner's paragraph. Answer 3 questions.

1

What do I remember
most?

2

Where do I want more
details?

3

What makes this person
unique?

No grammar policing. Focus on the story.

Rules for writing in English that nobody teaches you.

1

Short sentences hit harder.

"I applied. I got rejected. I applied again."

2

Start with action, not context.

"The goat escaped." — not "Growing up on a farm in Chitre, I learned many things..."

3

Use YOUR voice.

If you speak Spanglish, your essay can reflect that. Authenticity > perfection.

4

Delete the first paragraph.

Your real essay starts where you stopped warming up.

5

Read it out loud.

If it sounds weird when you say it, it sounds weird when they read it.

YOUR CHALLENGE

Tonight, don't write an essay.

Write one truth about yourself that no transcript can show.

The U For You Essay Starter Kit

- Your best stories (failure, pride, difference, problem)
- Power verbs cheat sheet
- Sentence starters for every level
- Common mistakes to avoid

The U For You

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